The Death of Innocence

By Nikki Giovanni

This selection is listed as a Prose Poem and contained in Giovanni's book of poetry. Check with your tournament for to determine in which category to enter this selection: PROSE or POETRY

MAMIE TILL-MOBLEY: (Pg 16) I wanted the world to see what they did to my boy. I wanted Emmett's death to be the last death. I wanted Emmett's death to kill American innocence. I wanted Emmett's death to be not only the death of my boy but *the death of innocence.* I wanted Mississippi, I wanted America, to give us justice. And I prayed that I would live long enough to see it.

INTRODUCTION

In 1955, when 14-year-old Emmett Till traveled from his home in Chicago to stay with a great-uncle in Tallahatchie County, Mississippi., his mother was nervous. Though the world was changing — the Brown v. Board of Education *decision had come the year before — the Deep South was still a dangerous place to be black. The murder of Emmett Till was evidence of the decades-old codes of violence exacted upon Black men and women for breaking the rules of white supremacy. But rather than bending to the intimidation and psychic horror caused by the savage*

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murder, Till's family, along with national newspapers and civil rights organizations – including the NAACP used his death to strike a blow against racial injustice and terrorism.

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MAMIE TILL-MOBLEY: (Pg 13-16) It must have been the waiting. The waiting had to be the worst of it. The only possible, the only possible, the very only possible thing worse than the waiting might be couldn't be would be the waiting being over. The knowing. The knowing they had killed your boy. Not killed. Killed could be an automobile accident. He could be walking down the road with that sort of doo-wop walk he developed as a result of being a breech birth with a knee caught against his chest almost choking him to death before he had a chance to live or that limp could be a result of polio. You had to be grateful that the only scar left was that limp and, of course, that stutter. That stutter that was so frustrating to him because he didn't want to stutter, the other kids would tease him; he wanted to talk strong and manly like he imagined his Daddy did. He wanted to be strong and take care of his mother. And

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be wonderful and great and show the world how wonderful he was. Yes. Maybe he was walking down the road on the way back to Uncle Mose's house. Dreaming as he was prone to do. Not just daydreaming like some children sitting in a window on a rainy day wanting to go out but dreamy like he had plans like he was talking to someone from somewhere else. Just not paying attention. How many times had you tried to teach him: Pay attention, Bo. And he smiled that baby-ish smile, that sweet smile, that I'm a good boy Mama smile and said "okay" and went right on not paying attention. Not killed. This was, after all, Mississippi. Killed could be, most likely was, probably was two or three or four mean white boys riding around in a pickup truck. Emmett was on the road alone maybe going to Bryant's to get some bubble gum or some nickel candy maybe some of those windmill cookies 2 for 5 cents and those poor Mississippi crackers were jealous of his shoes and his pants and his white shirt that he wore like he saw a picture of his Daddy wearing a white shirt with the sleeves rolled up. He had the ring on LT May 25, 1943. His Daddy's ring. He was almost big enough to

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wear it on his ring finger. It was just a little too big so he had wrapped it. Those jealous Mississippi crackers, four or five, maybe six boys riding around in a pickup truck looking for something to do to any girl they could find alone or somebody Black too small to defend himself. Maybe those jealous crazy Mississippi boys grabbed him and wrestled him down. Maybe they hit him and kicked him and threw him in the river. They didn't know they didn't care that he couldn't swim and maybe they watched him flailing and they laughed and drove off and my baby tried and tried but the water pulled him down and he had to give up his spirit. Maybe that's what they mean when they say killed. Emmett was missing. That's what the phone call in the middle of the night said. That he was missing. Mose put his wife on the Chicago train then went calling on everyone who might could help. They didn't want to call me or Mama too early maybe it could get solved without having to make that call. But they had to call. Emmett is missing. Mr. Bryant and Mr. Milam came to get him in the middle of the night. It was 2:00 A.M. and that's not an hour people come to get you when they only intend to

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teach you a lesson; that's the hour they come when they intend to murder you. There was someone else in the truck. A woman. There was a Black man in the truck bed. "It's Mr. Bryant, Uncle Mose. Open the door." No shame. No sense that there was anything to hide. "I want the boy from Chicago. The one who did all that talking." They offered to pay. They offered to whip him good. They said he was simple-minded and didn't know what he was saying. They said please. But they took my boy. "You don't need no socks, boy. Get on out here." "I never put on shoes without socks," he said. Never understanding the danger. Just a fourteen-year-old boy trying to impress his Mississippi cousins. They would laugh at his stutter; they would ape his doo-wop walk. He wanted to show them he wasn't afraid. Talk to that woman in the store, if you're so tough. She's a white woman. If you so tough in Chicago. talk to that woman. They knew. They knew the danger. They knew he would probably take a good whipping from somebody: Mr. Bryant, Uncle Mose. Somebody would show him that just because he was from Chicago his Mama was from Webb and they were from Money, and this is

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Mississippi and the cousins knew how this system worked not the cripple stuttering boy from Chicago. With his ring and his pants and his soft shoes and his white shirt. And that hat on the side of his head. They would show him. Never thinking three days later there would be a knock at the door. At first nobody knew. Whatever was said was said. The Black community held its breath, but Bryant was away taking fish or crabs or something with his half-brother J. W. Milam. Milam was a mean cracker. Bragged he knew how to take care of niggers. Didn't hesitate to show anyone. Three days passed and nothing was said. But Bryant came home. Tired. Unhappy. With not much more money than he left with. Working too hard for a good-looking white man and not making much money. Some little Black Judas whispered: What you going to do about that boy from Chicago who did all that talking to your wife? Carolyn Bryant hadn't said a word about it. She knew what would happen. She didn't have to be a nice person, a concerned person, a person with a conscience. She just knew what would happen and she didn't want it on her plate. Milam's wife who stayed

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with Carolyn while the men were away trying to make a little extra money knew what would happen. She knew what her husband would do. She knew what he did to her; she knew what he did to the children. She didn't want it on her plate. But some little Black Judas without even the thirty pieces without even a piece of candy or a cookie. Some little jealous Black Judas whispered to Bryant: What you going to do? Did he think there would be a show? That Bryant would take Emmett to the front of the store. strip his shirt off and give him five or ten lashes? Did he think it would be fun to see my boy, a fourteen-year-old. a barely fourteen-year-old cry for mercy? Did he think that would make his life in Mississippi any better? What could he have been thinking? But whatever he was thinking, it couldn't have been that Bryant and Milam would take Emmett out at 2:00 A.M. throw him in the back of the pickup and take him to Milam's barn. No one would think they would strip his clothes off of him to make fun of his penis. No one would think they would handle him like they did. That they would beat him and beat him and then the cutting started. Then they beat him, and Emmett's eye

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popped out. There was blood, Emmett's blood all over that barn. The Black man beat him, too. Just so the white men could think he would not testify against them. Finally, mercifully, they put a bullet in his head. But I know my baby was gone way before that. I know Jesus reached into that barn and took Emmett away. I know they sat on a cloud and watched the horror but Emmett was not in that barn when they started putting things in every orifice that they could. Emmett was not in that barn when they started the cutting. No. Emmett was not in that barn. They wrapped the barbed wire around what was left of his neck and told that Negro to attach it to the cotton-gin fan. They hauled his body to the Tallahatchie River. Even they must have known what a horrible thing they had done. Even they must have been ashamed. But, no, killed did not describe what they did to my boy. Three days later when his body was found they wanted to bury him in Mississippi. I wanted him home in Chicago. I wanted the world to see what they did to my boy. I wanted Emmett's death to be the last death. I wanted Emmett's death to kill American innocence. I wanted Emmett's death to be

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